

A DESIGN SYSTEM PLAYBOOK · 2026

The Playbook, Bound.

A constraint system for editorial documents —
cool canvas, single accent, serif carries
hierarchy.

What's inside this playbook

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CHAPTER 01

The Problem

Word document gray is not neutral — it's stale

AI can produce a 50-page playbook in minutes. Most of them land as gray Calibri walls on pure-white pages — technically readable, but nothing about the page invites you to keep reading.

WHY THIS HAPPENS

Without a constraint system, every session drifts toward defaults — system fonts, blue-gray neutrals, no rhythm. The output looks like a Word document because that's what training data is full of.

WHAT'S MISSING

Not capability. Not effort. The missing piece is *discipline*: a small set of rules that an agent will not break, no matter how the prompt drifts.

NOTE Polished typography on bad content is "polished mediocrity." Quire's job is the typography. You bring the argument.

1

The number of chromatic colors in a Quire document. Sky blue #3a82c4 — and nothing else.

Every "category color," every "success green," every "warning red" spends visual budget. A document that needs differentiation uses gray weight, not a second hue.

CHAPTER 02

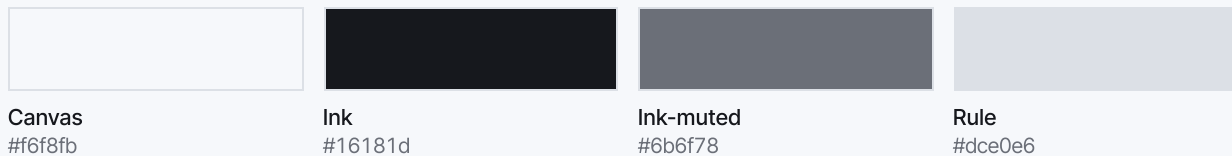
The Constraint Language

Four constraints carry everything

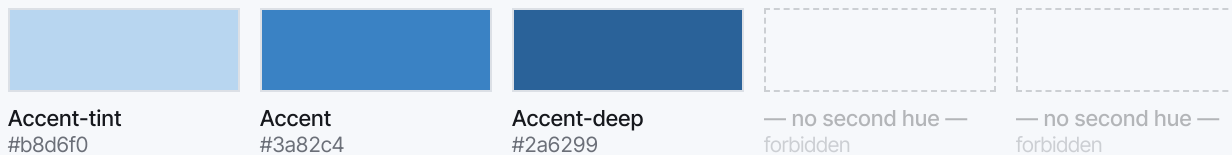
Quire is not a UI framework. It's **four pillars and ten rules** — enough structure for consistent output, narrow enough that every document still feels composed rather than templated.

COLOR · SINGLE ACCENT, NO SECOND HUE

SURFACE AND TEXT · COOL GRAYS (B ≥ G ≥ R)



ACCENT · SKY BLUE, LOCKED SYSTEM-WIDE



TYPE, SPACING, CADENCE

- **Type** — one serif (Fraunces) carries 78pt to 10pt; sans for chrome only; two weights (400/500).
- **Spacing** — 4pt base, seven tiers, asymmetric margins (left tighter than right).
- **Cadence** — every 5–7 content pages, reset the eye with a divider, pull-quote, or stat page.

Default document vs. Quire

Same content, different rules. The defaults are not neutral — they encode decisions that fight against editorial reading.

ELEMENT	DEFAULT DOC	QUIRE
Canvas	Pure white #ffffff	Cool canvas #f6f8fb
Body font	Calibri / Arial fallback	Fraunces, opsz 14, SOFT 50
Grays	Neutral or warm ($R \geq B$)	Cool-toned ($B \geq G \geq R$)
Accent colors	Multi-color, no ceiling	Sky blue only, no second hue
Rhythm	Continuous body wall	Visual reset every 5–7 pages

CHAPTER 03

The Page Archetypes

A 50-page wall of body text is not a book — it's a transcript. The rhythm is what makes it readable.

— Quire design notes

Seven archetypes, one rule of cadence

Every page in a Quire document belongs to one of seven archetypes. The discipline isn't picking the right one — it's **knowing when to break the rhythm**.

THE ARCHETYPES

- **Cover** — page 1, full-bleed accent or canvas, oversized title
- **TOC** — page 2, eyebrow + numbered list with leader rules
- **Chapter divider** — lightened-accent tint, chapter number + title only
- **Standard content** — most pages, h1/h2/h3, body, lists, callouts
- **Stat-anchor** — used 1–2× per document, oversized figure as hero
- **Comparison** — three-column compare table introducing a trade-off
- **Pull-quote** — half-page editorial quote, max one per chapter

THE CADENCE RULE

Every 5–7 content pages must contain a visual reset: a chapter divider, a pull-quote page, or a stat-anchor. Without it, readers lose orientation. With it, they skim productively — and come back to the parts that earn their attention.

EXERCISE Count pages between resets in your last long-form document. If any stretch goes over seven content pages, you've found where readers stopped.

COLOPHON

This playbook was set with Quire.

Twelve pages, one accent color (sky blue #3a82c4), one serif family (Fraunces), one sans for chrome (Inter Tight). Eleven content pages plus this colophon. Page count is even; covers and dividers fall on odd pages.

Quire is a constraint system, not a generator. It can compose this document because the document follows its own rules. If a Quire-styled output ever breaks these rules, the rules — not the document — are wrong.

SKILL.md · CHEATSHEET.md · references/design.md

assets/templates/playbook.html

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